RESOURCE 2

The Color in Pastry

Color theory for buttercream flowers



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> *Color is the fastest way to change how a cupcake bouquet feels. The same rose piped in a muted dusty pink reads as vintage and calm; piped in a saturated coral it reads as bold and festive. This guide gives you a simple, practical color theory built for buttercream, so you can mix with confidence instead of guessing drop by drop.*

Why Color Theory Matters in Buttercream

Many home bakers learn piping first and color second, and then wonder why a beautiful flower looks flat or muddy. The truth is that color decisions do half of the design work. A well-chosen palette makes simple petals look professional, while a poor one can hide excellent piping.

Buttercream is a forgiving but unusual canvas. It starts a creamy ivory because of the butter, it is opaque, it reflects light softly, and it changes color as it rests. Understanding a few core ideas lets you predict those changes and plan around them.

- **Color wheel:** how colors relate to each other.
- **Value, saturation, temperature:** the three dials that change any color.
- **Mixing:** how to build colors with gel food coloring, one drop at a time.
- **Harmony:** which colors work together in a bouquet.
- **Troubleshooting:** how to prevent bleeding, graying, and surprises.

The Color Wheel: Primary, Secondary, and Tertiary

The color wheel is a circle that arranges hues so you can see how they relate. In pastry we work with the traditional red-yellow-blue model, because that is how gel food colorings behave when you blend them.

Primary colors

Red, yellow, and blue are the primaries. In theory they cannot be made by mixing other colors, and every other hue comes from them. In practice, gel colors sold as "red" may lean orange or pink, so keep a true-leaning set if you can: a warm red, a cool red or pink, a lemon yellow, and a royal blue.

Secondary colors

Mix two primaries in equal amounts and you get a secondary: red plus yellow makes orange, yellow plus blue makes green, and blue plus red makes violet. Because gel is highly concentrated, start with one drop of each and adjust.

Tertiary colors

A tertiary color sits between a primary and the secondary next to it: red-orange, yellow-orange, yellow-green, blue-green, blue-violet, and red-violet. These in-between shades are where much of the elegance lives. Coral is a red-orange, chartreuse is a yellow-green, and teal is a blue-green.

GROUP	COLORS	HOW YOU GET THEM
Primary	Red, yellow, blue	Straight from the gel bottle

GROUP	COLORS	HOW YOU GET THEM
Secondary	Orange, green, violet	Equal parts of two primaries
Tertiary	Red-orange, yellow-orange, yellow-green, blue-green, blue-violet, red-violet	A primary plus a bit more of its neighbor

> **Practice tip**
>
> Make a small color wheel on parchment with a spoonful of white buttercream per hue. Keep it near your workspace as a visual map. It takes ten minutes and saves hours of trial and error.

Value, Saturation, and Temperature

Once you know the hue (the name of the color), three dials change how that hue looks. Learning to move each dial separately is the biggest step toward professional palettes.

Value: light to dark

Value is how light or dark a color is. In buttercream, white is your lightener and it is already built in, since the base is buttercream. Pale pastels need only a toothpick tip of gel. To go darker you add more gel, a tiny bit of a darker hue, or a touch of cocoa for a natural deepening.

Saturation: vivid to muted

Saturation is the intensity of a color. A fully saturated red is loud; add a hint of its opposite (green) or a speck of brown or gray and it softens. Muted, slightly grayed colors are called dusty or antique tones, and they are very popular in modern floral design.

Temperature: warm to cool

Reds, oranges, and yellows feel warm; blues, greens, and violets feel cool. Buttercream itself leans warm because of the butter, which is why blues and violets can look a little greenish or gray unless you account for it. Pairing warm and cool colors in one bouquet creates depth.

DIAL	QUESTION IT ANSWERS	QUICK FIX
Value	Is it too light or too dark?	Add gel a toothpick at a time, or blend in more white buttercream
Saturation	Is it too loud or too flat?	Mute with a speck of brown or the opposite hue
Temperature	Does it feel warm or cool?	Nudge toward yellow-red for warm, blue for cool

Mixing Color in Buttercream with Gel

Always use gel food coloring (or a concentrated paste) rather than liquid coloring. Liquid thins the frosting, weakens the structure, and makes petals droop. Gel gives rich color with very little moisture.

The drop-by-drop method

1. Start with a clean bowl of buttercream at the right piping consistency. Scoop out only what you need for one color.
2. Dip a clean toothpick into the gel and swirl it into the buttercream. Use the toothpick, not the bottle, for pastels.
3. Mix thoroughly with a spatula, pressing out streaks, for at least 30 seconds.
4. Compare the color on a white plate under natural light.
5. Add more in tiny increments. You can always add, but you can't take color away without adding more buttercream.

How many drops?

These are starting points per 1 cup of buttercream. Brands of gel differ, so treat them as a guide, not a law.

DEPTH	GEL AMOUNT PER 1 CUP	TYPICAL USE
Whisper pastel	1 toothpick tip	Baby tones, blush, mint
Soft pastel	2 to 3 toothpick tips	Spring bouquets, bridal
Medium	1 to 3 drops	Classic rose, sunny yellow
Deep or saturated	4 to 8 drops, plus resting time	Burgundy, navy, emerald

Let it rest: color deepens in 24 hours

The single most important rule in buttercream color is patience. Gel color continues to develop as it dissolves into the fat. A shade that looks right today can look noticeably darker tomorrow. Pastels deepen subtly; deep colors can go two or three shades darker.

> **The 24-hour rule**
>
> Mix pastels slightly lighter than your target and deep colors a little lighter than you want, then rest them covered at room temperature (within safe limits) or refrigerated. Follow food-safety guidelines: buttercream containing dairy should not sit out for long, so refrigerate for longer rests and bring it back to a soft, piping-ready texture before use. Stir gently to avoid adding air bubbles.

Matching colors across batches

- Mix one large batch of each main color instead of several small ones.
- Write down your drop counts, buttercream amounts, and the brands you used.
- Save a small swatch on parchment, labeled and dated, to compare later.
- Keep a spoonful of the original color to tint the next batch to match.

Creating Neutrals, Earth Tones, and Nudes

Neutrals are the quiet stars of a bouquet. They calm bright colors, make a design feel mature, and give your florals a natural look. They are also where bakers most often make gray frosting by accident, so go slowly.

Building a neutral

A true neutral is made by combining complementary colors, such as red and green, in balanced amounts. Added gently, they dull each other into brown or gray. You can also use a natural starting point, like a spoon of cocoa or a drop of brown gel.

Earth tones

Terracotta, clay, rust, olive, and sand are earth tones. Start with orange-red and add a touch of brown for terracotta. Add a bit of green and brown to yellow for mustard and olive. Earth tones suit autumn and boho designs.

Nude and skin-tone neutrals

Nude shades range from warm cream to caramel to deep mocha. Begin with a tiny speck of brown or ivory gel in white buttercream, then fine-tune with a hint of pink for warmth or yellow for golden notes. Because butter is yellow, nudes can turn peachy; a micro-touch of violet cancels excess yellow.

Dusty colors

A dusty color is a normal color with the saturation turned down. To make dusty rose, start with pink, then add a speck of brown or gray. To make dusty blue, start with blue and add a touch of gray or a hint of its complement, orange. Dusty sage is green plus a bit of gray or brown.

MIX GUIDE	STARTING POINT	ADD A SMALL AMOUNT OF	RESULT
Dusty rose	Pink	Brown or gray	Muted vintage pink
Mauve	Pink + violet	Gray	Soft purple-pink
Sage	Green	Gray or brown	Gray-green herb tone
Dusty blue	Blue	Gray or a hint of orange	Soft slate blue
Terracotta	Orange	Brown, a hint of red	Warm clay
Mustard	Yellow	Brown, a hint of green	Antique gold
Cream/ivory	White buttercream	Nothing, or a speck of yellow	Warm white
Taupe	Brown	Gray, a speck of violet	Cool earthy neutral
Nude/blush	White buttercream	Pink and brown	Warm skin tone

> **Rule of thumb**
>
> Fix a color that is too bright by adding a tiny amount of its opposite on the wheel, one toothpick tip at a time. Too much and you're headed for gray.

Deep Red and True Black Without the Bitter Taste

Red and black take a lot of gel, and excess gel can taste bitter or chemical. The solution is a combination of planning, a good base, and time.

Red

- Start with a strong red gel (a no-taste or tasteless formula, if available).
- Begin with a pink or light red base; reds become redder over time.
- Mix in about 1 tablespoon of gel per cup if you're going very dark, and rest it 12 to 24 hours.
- A small amount of cocoa can deepen a burgundy or red velvet shade without extra gel.
- Add a pinch of salt or a few drops of vanilla to balance any slight bitterness.

Black

- Never start with white buttercream. Start with chocolate buttercream and add black gel. It's far easier to reach black from a dark base.
- If you want black without chocolate flavor, use a small amount of dark cocoa powder plus black gel and rest overnight.
- Aim for charcoal or soft black for flowers. A dark gray-black still looks black in a bouquet.

> **Honest expectations**
>
> Very deep colors will always need time. If your frosting is gray or pinkish at the start, rest it overnight before adding more gel. Over-coloring is the main cause of off flavors.

Taste and texture

Saturated colors can slightly stain the mouth and teeth. Mention that in your menu notes for events and plan to use dark colors for accents rather than for every cupcake. For wedding or event work, balance a dark accent with lots of cream or blush so the overall effect stays light.

Color Harmonies for Cupcake Bouquets

A harmony is a recipe for combining colors so they feel balanced. You don't need to memorize the names; pick the pattern that fits the mood and the occasion.

Monochromatic

One hue in several values. A bouquet of blush, rose, and deep raspberry feels refined and cohesive. This is the safest harmony and perfect for beginners. Vary the value so the flowers don't blur together.

Analogous

Hues that sit side by side on the wheel, such as yellow, yellow-orange, and orange. Analogous palettes feel natural and harmonious, like a sunset. Pick one dominant color, one supporting, and a small accent.

Complementary

Colors directly opposite each other: red and green, blue and orange, yellow and violet. They create the highest contrast and a lot of energy. Use one as the main color and the other as an accent, and soften both with creams or dusty versions.

Split complementary

One color plus the two hues on either side of its opposite. Coral with teal and soft blue is an example. You get contrast with a bit less tension than a pure complementary pair.

Triadic

Three colors evenly spaced around the wheel, such as red, yellow, and blue, or orange, green, and violet. These are lively and playful; keep the saturation low or use pastels to avoid a child's-toy look unless that's the goal.

HARMONY	WHEEL POSITION	MOOD	BOUQUET EXAMPLE
Monochromatic	One hue, many values	Elegant, calm	Blush, rose, raspberry
Analogous	Neighbors	Warm, natural	Butter yellow, apricot, peach
Complementary	Opposites	Bold, vivid	Dusty blue with apricot
Split complementary	One color + two beside its opposite	Balanced contrast	Coral, teal, soft blue
Triadic	Three evenly spaced	Playful, festive	Soft red, butter yellow, sky blue

Contrast and Hierarchy in a Floral Design

A bouquet is read the way a picture is: the eye lands on one place first, travels to a second, and rests on the rest. Color is your tool for guiding that journey.

The 60-30-10 guide

- **60 percent:** the dominant color, usually a soft or neutral shade.
- **30 percent:** the secondary color, which supports the first.
- **10 percent:** the accent, the brightest or darkest note, for focus.

Hero flower, supporting flowers, filler

Choose a hero flower (a large rose or peony) in the strongest color or the highest contrast against the base. Supporting flowers use mid-range values, and fillers (buds, leaves, tiny blossoms) are quiet. Green leaves always give a rest to the eye; vary their value between a light leaf green and a deeper one for dimension.

Contrast in value, not only hue

If you squint at your bouquet and everything looks the same gray, the contrast is too low. Include at least one clearly lighter and one clearly darker color. A simple test is to take a photo and convert it to black and white.

> **Design tip**
>
> Place the darkest or most saturated flower slightly off-center, and echo it with a smaller dot of the same color elsewhere. This repeats the color and creates rhythm.

Colors by Occasion and Season

Color sets expectations before anyone takes a bite. Use these combinations as starting points and adapt them to your client's taste.

OCCASION OR SEASON	TYPICAL PALETTE	NOTES
Spring	Pastel pink, butter yellow, mint, lavender	Light, fresh, lots of leaf green
Summer	Coral, sunny yellow, sky blue, bright green	Keep reds and pinks cool in warm settings
Autumn	Terracotta, mustard, burgundy, olive	Add cream for balance
Winter	Deep navy, silver-gray, ivory, cranberry	Great for holiday and evening events
Weddings	Ivory, blush, sage, dusty blue	Match the couple's chosen palette
Baby showers	Soft pink, powder blue, mint, cream	Keep pastels very light
Birthdays	The honoree's favorite colors	Ask first, then simplify to 3 or 4 colors
Mother's Day	Peach, rose, lavender, cream	Soft and romantic
Valentine's Day	Raspberry, rose, blush, cream	One deep accent is enough

Common Color Mistakes and How to Fix Them

Color bleeding

Bleeding happens when a darker color seeps into an adjacent lighter one, usually because the frosting is too soft or damp, or because you used too much gel in a thin frosting. Prevent it by chilling piped details briefly, keeping dark

and light elements from touching for long, and using a stiffer consistency for the dark color. Store finished cupcakes in a cool place and serve them promptly, following food-safety guidelines.

Colors that oxidize or shift

Some colors change over time, especially in sunlight. Pink and purple can turn blue or gray; yellow can fade; blue can look greenish. Store decorated cupcakes away from direct light, and let colors develop before piping so you see the final shade. Test any unusual color in advance.

Buttercream that turns gray

Gray buttercream is almost always the result of mixing too many colors or adding black or brown in excess. It can also happen when you mix complementary colors in equal amounts. To fix it, add a bit more white buttercream and a warm accent such as yellow or pink to restore life. If a batch gets too muddy, use it for leaves, stems, or filler flowers.

Streaks and speckles

Streaks mean the color isn't fully blended. Mix longer, scrape the bowl, and let the color rest. Speckles happen when gel hasn't dissolved; for deep colors, dissolve the gel into a small spoon of buttercream first, then fold it in.

Different results on the same day

Light matters. A pastel can look yellow under a kitchen bulb and gray under daylight. Judge your color under the same light where you'll deliver the cupcakes whenever possible.

BEFORE YOU PIPE, CHECK

- ☐ I rested the color long enough for it to develop
- ☐ I judged the color under natural light
- ☐ I mixed enough of each color for the whole bouquet
- ☐ Dark and light colors are at a similar firmness
- ☐ I wrote down my drop counts and the buttercream amount
- ☐ I kept the buttercream within food-safety limits

The Mix Guide: Your Reference Table

These recipes are starting points per 1 cup of white or ivory buttercream. Use a toothpick for a "touch" and drops for stronger shades, and remember that colors deepen over 24 hours.

COLOR	MIX	NOTES
Blush pink	Pink, 1 toothpick tip	Stays soft; rest to deepen slightly
Rose	Pink, 3 to 4 drops, plus a touch of red	Medium; classic bouquet rose

COLOR	MIX	NOTES
Dusty rose	Pink + a touch of brown or gray	Mute slowly
Coral	Pink + orange (about 2:1)	Add yellow for peach
Peach	Orange + a touch of pink, very light	Use a toothpick
Butter yellow	Lemon yellow, 1 toothpick tip	Don't overdo; it intensifies
Mustard	Yellow + touch of brown + hint of green	Muted gold
Sage	Green + touch of gray or brown	Soft herb tone
Leaf green	Green + touch of yellow	Brighten with more yellow
Mint	Teal or green, 1 toothpick tip	Very light
Dusty blue	Blue + touch of gray	Hint of orange to dull it
Lavender	Violet, 1 toothpick tip, or pink + blue	Colors can shift blue
Burgundy	Red + a touch of violet/brown, rest overnight	Cocoa helps
Terracotta	Orange + brown + hint of red	Earthy
Navy	Blue + touch of violet/black, rest overnight	Needs time
Soft black	Chocolate buttercream + black gel	Rest overnight

Food Colors and Honest Expectations

Colors in buttercream aren't quite the same as the swatch on a bottle. Fat and dairy tint everything slightly yellow, light conditions shift hues, and extremely saturated shades require a lot of coloring.

- Pure white buttercream isn't possible with butter alone; a tiny touch of violet cancels yellow and gets closer, or use a white base made with a different fat if you prefer.
- Natural colorings (such as beet, spirulina, or turmeric) give gentler, earthier tones and can change flavor or fade; test before promising a particular shade.
- Check ingredient labels if a client has dietary needs or preferences. Colorings, cocoa, and add-in flavors may contain allergens; confirm with the label.
- Results will vary between brands, batches, and rooms. Always do a test swatch for important events.

> **A professional habit**
>
> When a client asks for an exact color, show a physical swatch sample and explain that the final shade can differ slightly. Setting honest expectations builds trust.

Planning a Palette for a Whole Bouquet

A cupcake bouquet is a group of small canvases that must read as one design. Before you mix anything, decide on the number of colors, the number of cupcakes, and how many of each shade you need. A bouquet of twelve cupcakes usually works best with three to five colors: one base shade, one or two flower shades, a leaf green, and a small accent.

Estimating how much to mix

As a rough guide, a swirl or a medium flower uses about 2 to 3 tablespoons of buttercream. A leaf or filler uses about 1 tablespoon. Add up your needs per color, then mix about one quarter more than the total. Running short in the middle of a bouquet is the most common reason for a mismatched shade.

ELEMENT	BUTTERCREAM PER CUPCAKE	TIP
Base swirl or layer	2 to 3 tbsp	Neutral or pale shade lets flowers pop
Hero flower	3 to 4 tbsp	Most saturated or highest contrast
Supporting flower	2 to 3 tbsp	Mid-value shade
Leaves and fillers	1 tbsp	Two greens, one light and one deep

Building the palette in four steps

1. Pick the mood in one word (romantic, playful, rustic, elegant).
2. Choose the dominant color and write its mix recipe.
3. Add a supporting color from the same harmony, then one accent.
4. Pipe a test on parchment and look at it from across the room.

Using the Palette Collection

The palette collection in this guide gives you 36 ready-made color schemes, each with four or five shades, a mood, an occasion, and a short mix note. The swatches are realistic buttercream tones, not neon print colors. Treat each as a map rather than a rule.

- Pick a palette that matches the occasion or the client's decor.
- Mix the hero and supporting colors first; they set the tone of the whole bouquet.
- Adjust each shade up or down in value to suit your lighting and brand of gel.
- Save your final recipe in your notebook so you can repeat it exactly.

> **Make it yours**
>
> Swap one palette color for a favorite and notice how the mood shifts. A single change in the accent shade can turn a vintage bouquet into a modern one.

Photographing your work

Color looks different on a screen than in person. Shoot your cupcakes near a window with soft daylight, against a white or neutral background, and avoid yellow kitchen bulbs. Keep a gray or white card in the frame to help you judge color accuracy later.

Next Step

Choose one palette from the collection that follows and make a half-batch of each color. Label the bowls, rest them overnight, and pipe a small test bouquet the next day. Notice how the colors changed, write down what you'd adjust, and keep that swatch in your color notebook.

YOUR COLOR PRACTICE PLAN

- ☐ Make a practice color wheel with buttercream
- ☐ Mix one pastel, one dusty, and one deep color
- ☐ Rest them 24 hours and compare
- ☐ Pipe a monochromatic bouquet
- ☐ Pipe an analogous bouquet
- ☐ Pipe a complementary bouquet with a soft accent
- ☐ Record your best mixes in your notebook

Palette library: 36 ready-to-mix color schemes

Blush Garden · Romantic, soft · Weddings



Blush #F4D6D6 | Rose #E3A5A9 | Ivory #FBF5E8 | Sage Leaf #A9B99A

How to mix: Pink at one toothpick tip for blush; add a touch of red for rose; green plus a speck of gray for sage.

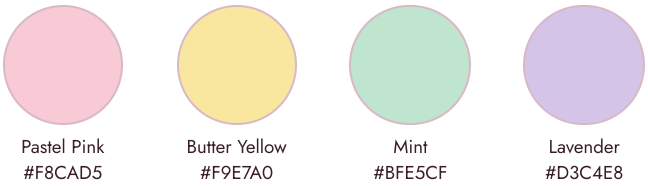
Dusty Rose Vintage · Antique, gentle · Anniversaries



Dusty Rose #C99AA0 · Mauve #A9808F · Cream #F6EBD9 · Moss #8E9B76 · Taupe #B5A397

How to mix: Pink plus a speck of brown for dusty rose; add violet and gray for mauve; green plus brown for moss.

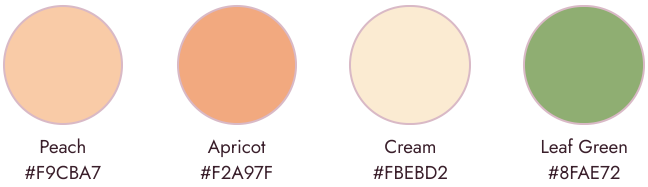
Spring Sorbet · Fresh, cheerful · Spring brunch



Pastel Pink #F8CAD5 · Butter Yellow #F9E7A0 · Mint #BFE5CF · Lavender #D3C4E8

How to mix: One toothpick tip each of pink, lemon yellow, teal, and violet per cup of buttercream.

Peach Sunrise · Warm, glowing · Mother's Day



Peach #F9CBA7 · Apricot #F2A97F · Cream #FBEBD2 · Leaf Green #8FAE72

How to mix: Orange with a touch of pink for peach; more orange and a hint of yellow for apricot.

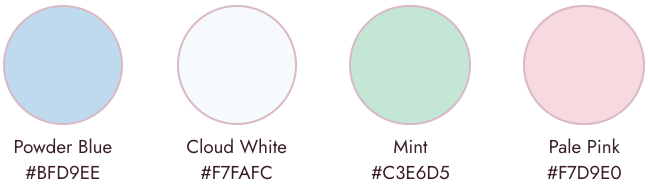
Lavender Fields · Dreamy, calm · Bridal showers



Lavender #C9B6E4 · Lilac #DCCDEF · Soft White #FAF7FB · Sage #A8B5A0 · Plum #8E6C9C

How to mix: Violet at a toothpick tip for lilac; double for lavender; violet plus a touch of pink and gray for plum.

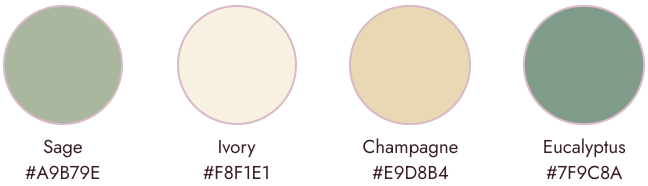
Baby Blue Cloud · Sweet, airy · Baby showers



Powder Blue #BFD9EE · Cloud White #F7FAFC · Mint #C3E6D5 · Pale Pink #F7D9E0

How to mix: Blue at one toothpick tip for powder blue; teal for mint; keep all four very light.

Sage and Ivory · Natural, quiet · Weddings



Sage #A9B79E · Ivory #F8F1E1 · Champagne #E9D8B4 · Eucalyptus #7F9C8A

How to mix: Green plus gray for sage; a speck of yellow plus brown for champagne; green plus teal and gray for eucalyptus.

Dusty Blue Wedding · Classic, serene · Weddings



Dusty Blue #9DB4C8 · Slate #6F8CA3 · Ivory #F9F3E6 · Blush #F0D5D3 · Silver Sage #B5C2B2

How to mix: Blue plus a touch of gray for dusty blue; more blue and gray for slate; rest overnight.

Terracotta Boho · Earthy, warm · Boho weddings



Terracotta #C97B5B · Clay #D9A58A · Sand #EAD8C0 · Olive #8A8C58 · Cream #F7EDDC

How to mix: Orange plus brown and a hint of red for terracotta; lighten with more buttercream for clay.

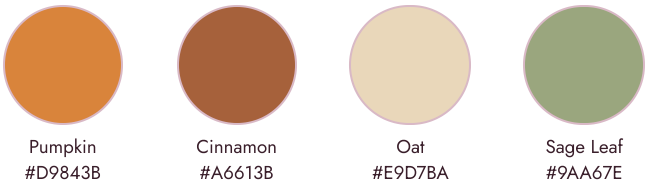
Autumn Harvest · Rich, cozy · Thanksgiving



Mustard #D6A332 | Burnt Orange #C9692F | Burgundy #8A2F3F | Olive #7C7D45 | Cream #F4E7CE

How to mix: Yellow plus brown and a green hint for mustard; orange plus brown for burnt orange; red plus violet for burgundy.

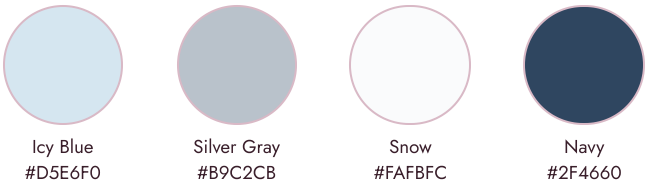
Pumpkin Spice · Warm, inviting · Fall parties



Pumpkin #D9843B | Cinnamon #A6613B | Oat #E9D7BA | Sage Leaf #9AA67E

How to mix: Orange with a touch of yellow for pumpkin; add brown for cinnamon.

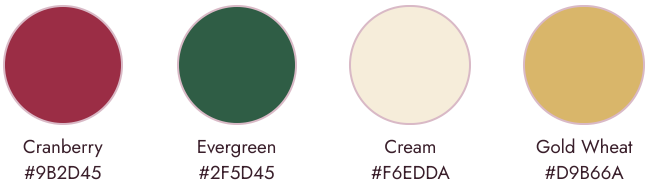
Winter Frost · Cool, crisp · Winter events



Icy Blue #D5E6F0 | Silver Gray #B9C2CB | Snow #FAFBFC | Navy #2F4660

How to mix: Blue at one toothpick tip for icy blue; gray for silver; blue plus violet for navy, rest overnight.

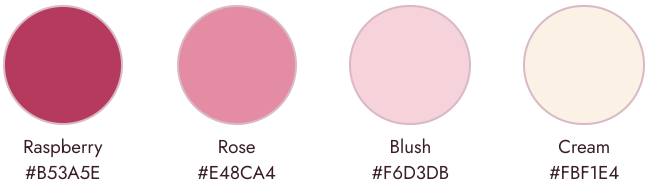
Holiday Berry · Festive, bold · Christmas



Cranberry #9B2D45 | Evergreen #2F5D45 | Cream #F6EDDA | Gold Wheat #D9B66A

How to mix: Deep red plus a hint of violet; green plus a speck of blue; rest both overnight.

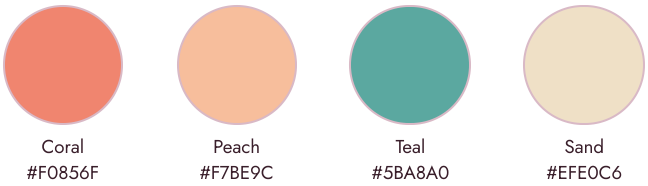
Raspberry Romance · Passionate, soft · Valentine's Day



Raspberry #B53A5E · Rose #E48CA4 · Blush #F6D3DB · Cream #FBF1E4

How to mix: Pink plus red for raspberry; pink alone for rose; very light pink for blush.

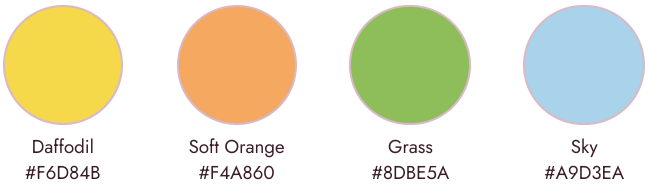
Coral Reef · Vibrant, summery · Summer parties



Coral #F0856F · Peach #F7BE9C · Teal #5BA8A0 · Sand #EFE0C6

How to mix: Pink plus orange for coral; blue plus green for teal; keep teal as accent.

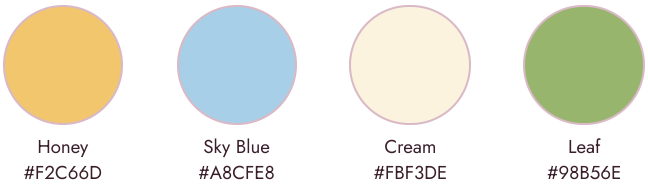
Sunny Meadow · Bright, happy · Birthdays



Daffodil #F6D84B · Soft Orange #F4A860 · Grass #8DBE5A · Sky #A9D3EA

How to mix: Lemon yellow for daffodil; add orange; green plus yellow for grass.

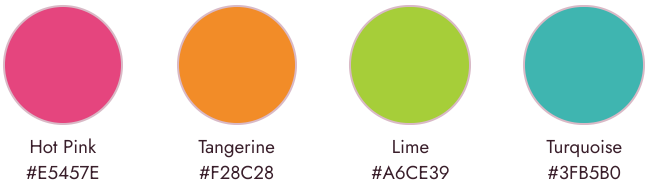
Sky and Honey · Light, optimistic · Garden parties



Honey #F2C66D · Sky Blue #A8CFE8 · Cream #FBF3DE · Leaf #98B56E

How to mix: Yellow plus a touch of orange for honey; blue at two toothpick tips for sky.

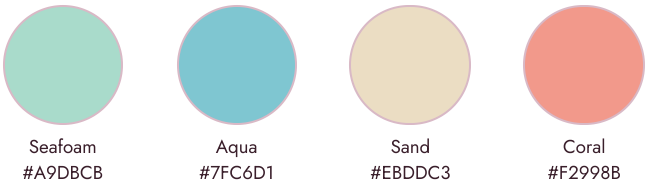
Tropical Sunset · Lively, saturated · Luaus



Hot Pink #E5457E · Tangerine #F28C28 · Lime #A6CE39 · Turquoise #3FB5B0

How to mix: Strong pink; orange plus a touch of yellow; yellow plus green; teal. Use as accents on cream.

Ocean Breeze · Fresh, coastal · Beach events



Seafoam #A9DBCB · Aqua #7FC6D1 · Sand #EBDDC3 · Coral #F2998B

How to mix: Teal at one toothpick tip for seafoam; teal plus blue for aqua.

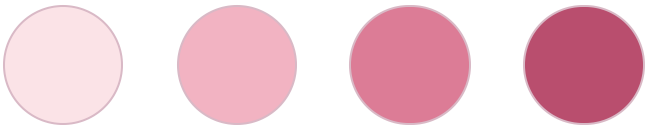
Garden Party · Colorful, balanced · Showers



Rose #E7A1B0 · Butter #F8E5A2 · Sky #B5D8EA · Fern #86AA6B · Cream #FCF4E4

How to mix: Pink, lemon yellow, blue, and green each at one to three drops; keep fern as the supporting hue.

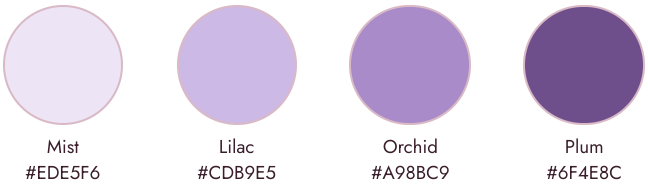
Monochrome Pink · Elegant, cohesive · Birthdays



Pale Pink #FBE3E7 · Pink #F2B3C2 · Rose #DC7C96 · Deep Rose #B94E6E

How to mix: Same pink in 1, 3, 6, and 10 drops; deep rose rests overnight.

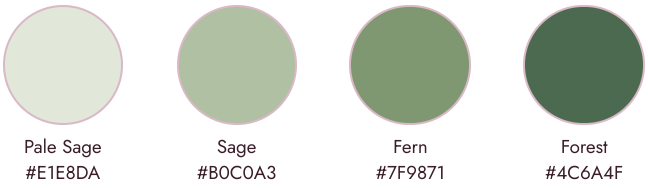
Monochrome Lavender · Soft, modern · Bridal showers



Mist #EDE5F6 · Lilac #CDB9E5 · Orchid #A98BC9 · Plum #6F4E8C

How to mix: Violet at 1, 2, 5, and 9 drops; add a speck of pink to warm.

Monochrome Sage · Calm, natural · Weddings



Pale Sage #E1E8DA · Sage #B0C0A3 · Fern #7F9871 · Forest #4C6A4F

How to mix: Green with a touch of gray at 1, 3, 6, and 10 drops; brown deepens forest.

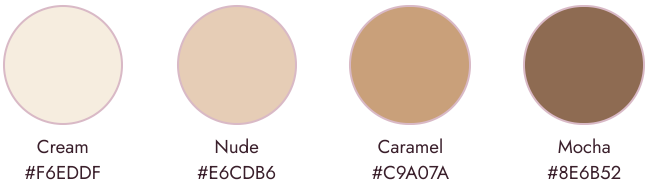
Sunset Ombre · Warm, gradient · Sunset parties



Butter #F9E39A · Apricot #F5B57B · Coral #EE8374 · Rose #D26F8A · Plum #8F5A85

How to mix: Pipe from yellow to plum: each shade moves one step toward red, then toward violet.

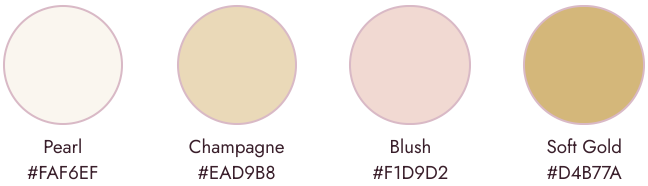
Neutral Nude · Sophisticated, minimal · Modern weddings



Cream #F6EDDF · Nude #E6CDB6 · Caramel #C9A07A · Mocha #8E6B52

How to mix: A speck of brown at 1, 2, 4, and 8 drops; pink adds warmth.

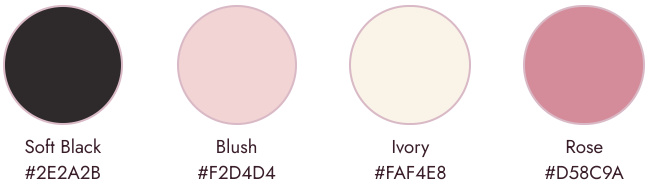
Champagne and Pearl · Luxe, light · Anniversaries



Pearl #FAF6EF | Champagne #EAD9B8 | Blush #F1D9D2 | Soft Gold #D4B77A

How to mix: Ivory base with a speck of yellow and brown for champagne.

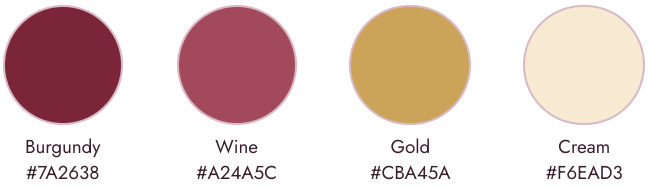
Black and Blush · Dramatic, modern · Evening events



Soft Black #2E2A2B | Blush #F2D4D4 | Ivory #FAF4E8 | Rose #D58C9A

How to mix: Black gel in chocolate buttercream; rest overnight; keep black as accent.

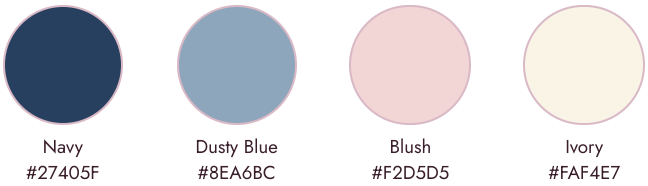
Burgundy and Gold · Opulent, rich · Fall weddings



Burgundy #7A2638 | Wine #A24A5C | Gold #CBA45A | Cream #F6EAD3

How to mix: Red plus violet or cocoa; rest overnight; gold from yellow plus brown.

Navy and Blush · Classic, elegant · Weddings



Navy #27405F | Dusty Blue #8EA6BC | Blush #F2D5D5 | Ivory #FAF4E7

How to mix: Blue plus violet for navy; rest overnight; use as a single accent.

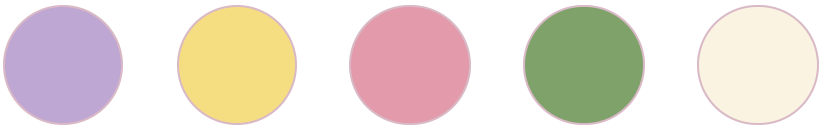
Emerald and Cream · Stately, fresh · Holidays



Emerald #2E7D5B · Mint #BCE0CD · Cream #F8EFD9 · Gold Wheat #D8BE76

How to mix: Green plus a speck of blue for emerald; rest overnight.

Cottage Garden · Cozy, floral · Tea parties



Wisteria #BFA7D4 · Buttercup #F5DE82 · Rose #E39AAA · Leaf #7FA26B · Cream #FBF3E1

How to mix: Violet, yellow, pink, and green at light to medium drops.

Retro Pastel · Playful, nostalgic · Birthdays



Mint #BFE6D3 · Peach #F9CDB0 · Pink #F4B6C8 · Powder Blue #BED8EE · Cream #FCF5E5

How to mix: Each color at 1 to 2 toothpick tips; keep all at the same pastel value.

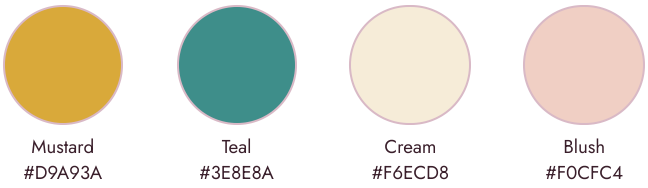
Rainbow Soft · Joyful, light · Kids' parties



Soft Red #EE8D90 · Soft Orange #F7B98A · Soft Yellow #F8E39D · Soft Green #AFD6A0 · Soft Blue #A8CBE8

How to mix: Use pastel amounts of each primary and secondary; keep value even.

Mustard and Teal · Modern, bold · Birthdays



Mustard
#D9A93A

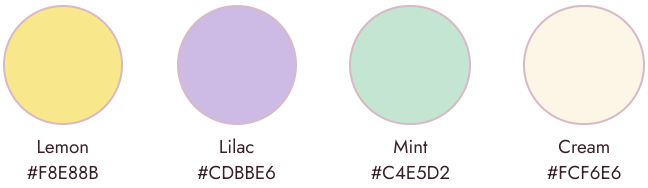
Teal
#3E8E8A

Cream
#F6ECD8

Blush
#F0CFC4

How to mix: Yellow plus brown for mustard; blue plus green for teal; use teal as the accent.

Lemon and Lilac · Light, spring · Spring brunch



Lemon
#F8E88B

Lilac
#CDBBE6

Mint
#C4E5D2

Cream
#FCF6E6

How to mix: Lemon yellow and violet at one toothpick tip each.

Rustic Wildflower · Natural, casual · Outdoor events



Wild Rose
#D9899A

Goldenrod
#E1B94F

Meadow
#8AAE6C

Bluebell
#8E9CCF

Linen
#F2E7D3

How to mix: Pink plus brown; yellow plus a touch of orange; green plus yellow; blue plus violet.